



BUYERS' GUIDE

ESTYLE

Selecting THE BEST WI-FI SOLUTION You Can Get Today



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The *Paradox of Choice* (Schwartz, 2004) argues that, eliminating consumer choices can greatly reduce anxiety for shoppers. When we consider the almost infinite choices of Wi-Fi routers available today, we begin to understand what Barry Schwartz was trying to tell us in his book.

In the interest of our readers, we decided to take on that anxiety ourselves to save you the trouble of figuring out which router you need to buy.

Top Wi-Fi solutions

Some recommendations from our team are given below.

Routers. TP-Link Archer C7 (v2) wins the value-for-money round here. Its price varies between ₹ 6867 and ₹ 7249 on various online retail stores. This router has also been shown to have the largest coverage and best speeds of routers reviewed at *TheWireCutter.com*. It misses some advanced features like Quality of Service (QoS) controls, iTunes server, jumbo frames and VPN server.

TP-Link TL-WDR3600 is a cheaper alternative that retails at ₹ 4370 on Flipkart. This router does not support 'ac' standard. Instead, it only supports 'n' standard, but for its price range, its performance is commendable. It comes with four gigabit Ethernet ports, two USB 2.0 ports, a switch for toggling your Wi-Fi network on and off, and a WPS button. But, it lacks the QoS feature.

ASUS RT-AC5300 features simultaneous triple-band support with Wi-Fi AC. Its 2.4GHz band can achieve speeds up to 1000Mbps, and the router comes with four antennae in MIMO4T4R configuration. ASUS claims a combined tri-band data rate of 4334Mbps for low-latency online gaming and smooth 4K streaming.

Broadcom's NitroQAMTM technology shows up in this router to boost its two

5GHz band data rates up to 4334Mbps and 2.4GHz up to 1000Mbps. The router also features 4x4 antenna design with AiRadar universal beam-forming for unbeatable wireless signal coverage. It costs around ₹ 47,000 on Amazon.

Netgear R6400 is a very capable mid-range 802.11ac router, which is an alternative to the more expensive ASUS RT-AC5300. It is not the fastest in its class, but has a strong feature set in terms of remote access, parental controls and network-attached storage. On these counts, it is a better router than the cheaper-but-faster TP-Link Archer C8. It retails for ₹ 12,800 on Amazon.

R6400 supports three spatial streams (with beam-forming) to deliver a maximum throughput of up to 1300Mbps on the 5GHz band, and up to 450Mbps on the 2.4GHz frequency band.

Wireless USB adapters. These work like an external Wi-Fi LAN card, and help you connect any old laptop or desktop that does not have inbuilt Wi-Fi, through a USB port. It also lets you set up a Wi-Fi hotspot using this dongle.

Wayona WYN 12 150Mbps 1T1R is one such model retailing at ₹ 298. You can use it even to connect to Raspberry Pi 2 running Raspbian.

Another popular option is Comfast CF-WU810N V2.0, which is cheaper and has lower ratings than Wayona model.

Leoxsys LEO-HG150N comes with an external antenna as well. However, it does not act as range extender to an already existing Wi-Fi network.

Range extenders. These help extend coverage and improve signal strength of an existing Wi-Fi router in order to eliminate dead zones in coverage within your home.

TP-Link TL-WA850RE is one of the most popular ones, selling at ₹ 1511 on Ama-

